

For example, when Google launched Chrome for free, or when they made an open source OS like Android, they made no effort to hide the fact that it also served their own interests to find more ways to get more people online. If anything, Zuckerberg's biggest error was not being more open about this also being in Facebook's best interests. A popular dig at Free Basics is that there are no promises that it'll remain ad-free. Does Android make any such promises? Does any other "free" platform or service you are currently enjoying promise that?

OUCH, MY PRIVATES!

A huge concern for people seems to be that Facebook will mine your data and make money off of it. Have you been living under a rock? Welcome to the internet! Your data is the new black gold! Name one company that doesn't mine your data and try and use it to get you to buy stuff? I'm not saying it's OK. I'm saying it's not new, and in fact is the norm for pretty much all the services you use – Google, Microsoft, Apple, Amazon... you name it. When they do overstep their bounds, privacy advocacy groups (the whistle blowers who pour over EULAs and such) will do what they do best and there will be a big uproar, and then we'll go back to liking like good sheep!

The bottom line is, whether there is a profit to be made or not, and whoever makes it, it's not reason enough to deprive a huge section of the population of the chance to come online.

Would we be OK if say Jimmy Wales were to try and start something similar? Surely he's not an evil profiteer like this Zuck fellow. Jimmy Wales for president! Oh. Wait. Wikipedia Zero already exists! Et tu Jimmy? Sure, they adhere to a much higher standard (or nobler one?) when it comes to privacy (<http://dgit.in/frbbsc4>), but aren't they messing with your precious net neutrality as well? If Wikipedia does it, it's Angelic ascent, but if the devil (Zuckerberg) does it then you want to clip his ghoulish wings.

I think the TRAI can easily revoke their green signal to Free Basics (should they give it in the first place). In fact, the best solution would be to start a time bound trial. A Globe Telecom white paper (<http://dgit.in/frbbsc5>) documents that "Even after the free Facebook campaign ended in April 2014, users continued to join Globe's

DID YOU KNOW?

Two years ago Open Compute Project a Facebook Connectivity lab project was launched to build more efficient, economical data centers. Once significant progress was made designs were open-sourced. Yes, evilcorp did some good.

network at a 2x rate of the pre-campaign baseline. The campaigns had an enduring impact on the rate of Internet adoption in the Philippines, even when access to Facebook was no longer free". What we all must realise is that if you see some good in Free Basics, it doesn't automatically make you pro-evil, or against net neutrality, or a baby-killer!

THE (SO CALLED) SOLUTIONS AND A SOBERING CONCLUSION

One argument suggests that Facebook can achieve its objectives with an ad supported model. You must've read about the growth in revenues figures that the company

most commonly suggested cap. This makes me take a step back and take a re-look at the problem. What kind of content or rather kind of media will rural folk most benefit from? Text? Is there enough vernacular text online? Are the people who really need the help even literate? Also understand that being able to write your name is hardly a measure of literacy. Can these as yet unexposed masses ever get onto the internet without a filtered experience?

When I first came online I went to alltheweb.com because someone told me to do so. Maybe a filtered experience is better for an internet-illiterate person in order not to get overwhelmed. Maybe what we'll end up doing is nothing more than taking someone who is illiterate, and putting them into the centre of a massive library with a million books, and saying, "Go uplift yourself!"

It's not like I believe that Free Basics is the way to go. I actually believe that everyone's got it wrong. Remember the OLPC example I said I would come back to? The one where illiterate kids were able



posted in another geography – the UK. What we don't realise is that ad revenues per instance of usage are indeed significantly lower than data charges paid by the consumer. If we are to really calculate whether this is or isn't a sustainable model via ads, we need to get much, much deeper into the TSP's operating costs. Simply pointing at and saying "oh look how much ad revenue (not profits) they made overall" isn't really a strong argument.

One of the other suggestions is to limit usage is by bandwidth instead of a walled garden. I remember reading 64 kbps as

to educate themselves and learn many new skills? They weren't given access to Wikipedia, they were given a heck of a lot of educational video content. That's how you uplift the backward in our country, by giving them access to video, which even Free Basics doesn't do. For me personally, I think Free Basics won't even scratch the surface of what India needs, but I'd much rather something scratch the surface while we look around for a powerful tool to bring down the huge wall that's dividing the technology haves and have nots. 🇮🇳